

Ibn al-Qifti, Tarikh al-Hukama

English Translation

Modern LaTeX Editions of Public-Domain Mathematics Manuscripts

About this reader

- Reader type - English Translation.
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IBN AL-QIFTĪ'S
TĀRĪKH AL-ḤUKAMĀ'
History of the Learned

كِتَابُ تَارِيخِ الْحُكَمَاءِ

لِجَمَالِ الدِّينِ أَبِي الْحَسَنِ عَلِيِّ بْنِ يُوسُفَ الْقُفُطِيِّ

BILINGUAL EDITION — ZWEISPRACHIGE AUSGABE — □□□□□□ □□□□□□□□

LEFT: Arabic Text || RIGHT: English Translation

ARABISCH: LINKS || ENGLISCH: RECHTS

Based on the edition by

Prof. Dr. Julius Lippert

Leipzig, Dieterich'sche Verlagsbuchhandlung, 1903

AUF GRUND DER VORARBEITEN AUG. MÜLLER'S

With critical apparatus and parallel English translations

بِتَأْيِيدِ اللَّهِ الْمُؤَفَّقِ

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Preface — Vorwort — □□□□□

This bilingual edition presents the Arabic text of Ibn al-Qiftī's تاريخ الحكماء (Tārīkh al-Ḥukamā', "History of the Learned") alongside English translations. The Arabic text is based on the critical edition prepared by Prof. Dr. Julius Lippert (Leipzig, 1903), which was itself founded upon the preparatory work of August Müller. The present edition aims to make this foundational biographical dictionary accessible to historians of mathematics and science who do not read Arabic.

Zur dieser Ausgabe:

Zweck dieser Zeilen ist es, diejenigen unter den Weisen zu erwähnen, deren Ruhm berühmt geworden ist, aus jedem Stamm und jeder Nation, alt und neu, bis zu meiner Zeit.

قَصَدْنَا بِهَذِهِ الطَّبْعَةِ أَنْ نُتَيْحَ هَذَا الْكِتَابَ الْمُهِّمَّ لِطُلَّابِ تَارِيخِ الْعُلُومِ

1 Introduction to the Work

Jamāl al-Dīn Abū al-Ḥasan ‘Alī ibn Yūsuf ibn Ibrāhīm ibn ‘Abd al-Wāḥid al-Shaybānī al-Qiftī (1172–1248 CE) was an Egyptian Arab scholar, historian, and Ayyubid vizier. Born in Qift (Coptos) in Upper Egypt, he studied in Cairo before moving to Jerusalem and later Aleppo, where he compiled most of his works. Of the twenty-six works known by title, only two survive: *Inbāḥ al-Ruwāt ‘alā Anbāḥ al-Nuḥāt* (containing some thousand biographies of Muslim scholars) and the present work.

The *تاريخ الحكماء* (*Tārīkh al-Ḥukamā’*, “History of the Learned”) is a biographical dictionary of 414 physicians, philosophers, astronomers, and scientists — including Greeks, Indians, Persians, and Arabs. The text preserved today is an epitome made in 1249/647 AH by محمد بن علي الخطيب (Muḥammad ibn ‘Alī al-Khaṭībī al-Zawzanī), a year after Ibn al-Qiftī’s death, from the longer original titled *كتاب إخبار العلماء بأخبار الحكماء* (*Kitāb Ikḥār al-‘Ulamā’ bi-Akḥbār al-Ḥukamā’*).

The present edition was prepared by **Prof. Dr. Julius Lippert** (1839–1909), building upon the preparatory work of August Müller. It was published in Leipzig by Dieterich’sche Verlagsbuchhandlung in 1903, with the support of the Royal Academy of Sciences in Berlin.

On the Arabic Text

The Arabic text in this edition follows the standard conventions of 19th-century Orientalist printing. The *hamza* and diacritical points are supplied where the manuscripts are ambiguous or defective. The editorial footnotes indicate manuscript variants using the sigla listed below.

Editorial Sigla

Siglum	Description
A	Berlin, Königliche Bibliothek, Cod. or. quart. 786
B	Berlin, Königliche Bibliothek, Cod. or. oct. 10053
C	Kairo, Biblothèque Nationale, Ms. I
D	Kairo, Biblothèque Nationale, Ms. II
V	Wien, Kaiserliche Hofbibliothek, Cod. Mixt. 783
M	München, Königliche Hof- und Staatsbibliothek, Cod. ar. 651

2 Author's Introduction

The author's introduction explains the purpose and method of the work.

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 .〇〇〇〇〇〇〇〇〇〇〇〇〇〇 *I have resolved — with
 God's aid — to mention those among the
 learned men whose fame has become
 celebrated, from every tribe and nation,
 ancient and modern, down to my own time;
 and to record what has been preserved from
 them of unique sayings, books they have
 composed, or sublime wisdom they have
 originated and which has been attributed to
 them. For I have seen that this is among
 matters that have been neglected and
 histories that have been abandoned; and in
 perusing this there is instruction by those
 who have passed and mention of those who
 come after. And this is instruction through
 which I hope for reward for myself and for
 its reader, God Most High willing. I have
 arranged it alphabetically so that it may be
 easily consulted. God is the One who grants
 success.*

Note: The word قَفَّيْتُهُ (qaffaytuhu) here means “I arranged it alphabetically” (literally: “I followed the letters [of the alphabet]”). This alphabetical arrangement was one of the earliest examples of systematic biographical dictionary arrangement in Arabic literature.

3.1 Thales [ثَالِس] [ثَالِس]

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*Thales — he is from the people of Miletus —
 and he lived in the time of King Cyrus, and he
 was the first to discourse on causes and
 reasons. He travelled to Egypt and studied
 with the astrologers, then returned to his
 country. He was the first to establish that the
 Moon receives its light from the Sun, and
 that the Sun is eclipsed according to
 calculation.*

3.2 Pythagoras فَيْثَاغُورَسْ

||

Pythagoras the Samian — he is from the people of Tyre — was the first to discourse on divine science (al-ʿilm al-ilāhī), and Socrates followed him in that. Pythagoras had left Egypt after studying with the astrologers and the Hermetists, and remained at that for forty years; then he returned to Tyre and departed from there to Italy, where he settled. He used to forbid the eating of beans and meat.

The tradition of Pythagoras studying in Egypt with the “astrologers and Hermetists” connects Greek wisdom to the Egyptian Hermetic tradition. The forty-year sojourn reflects the standard Arabic account of Pythagoras’s intellectual biography.

3.3 Socrates سُقْرَاطُ

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Socrates, disciple of Pythagoras, was called among the non-Arabs “Socrates.” He did not compose books, but rather spoke in the streets and marketplaces. He called to the abandonment of desires and the cultivation of noble virtues.

3.4 Plato أفلاطون

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 □□□□□□□□□□□□ □□□ .□□□□□□□□□□ *Plato the*
Platonist — he was the least disposed to
 dwell in houses — and he had a strong love
 for Socrates, and he inherited noble
 character traits from Socrates. He composed
 works on optics and established that looking
 at the naked Sun corrupts the eyesight, while
 looking at it in water or through glass does
 not corrupt it.

3.5 Aristotle [أَرِسْطُو طَالِيسْ]

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.□□□□□□□□□□ Aristotle, disciple of Plato,
was the most prolific composer of books
among them, and the most comprehensive in
the sciences. He composed on every art of
the arts. Plato used to call him “the chick of
the Academy” because of the strength of his
intelligence.

4.1 Euclid اقليدس

4.2 Archimedes [أَرَشِمِيدِسْ]

[illegible]

5 The Alexandrian School

The Alexandrian mathematicians and astronomers formed the bridge between classical Greek science and its Arabic reception.

5.1 Theon of Alexandria [ثَاوُئُسُ الإسْكَندَرَانِيّ]

||

Theon of Alexandria: a scholar in geometry
 and astronomy, and he lived in the time of
 Ptolemy. He has commentaries on the book
 of Euclid and on the book of the Almagest,
 and he used to teach in the school of
 Alexandria.

5.2 Hypatia [هَيْبَةُ قُسْتَرَى]

||

Hypatia daughter of
 Theon of Alexandria — she is the one called
 Qusturā — was the most learned of the
 people of her time in geometry and
 astronomy. She used to teach that in the
 school of Alexandria in the manner of her
 father, and she had commentaries on the
 book of Euclid and on the book of
 Diophantus.

Ibn al-Qiftī preserves one of the earliest biographical accounts of Hypatia (d. 415 CE). The name قُسْتَرَى (Qusturā) represents the Arabic rendering of her Greek name. Her commentary on Diophantus's Arithmetica is mentioned, which is of special interest to historians of algebra.

5.3 Ptolemy [بَطْلَمَيْوُس]

||

Ptolemy the Ptolemaean: a scholar
 in astronomy and geometry, and he
 composed the book of the Almagest, which is
 the most famous book of astronomy, and he
 established in it many principles which no
 one had preceded him to.

5.4 Diophantus [دِيُوفَانْطُس]

||

Diophantus of Alexandria: a scholar in
 algebra and equations, and he composed a
 book on that which he called "Algebra"
 (al-Jabr), containing thirteen discourses. He
 used to solve problems by means of
 unknown numbers.

6.1 Brahmagupta [بَرَهْمَجَبْت] [بَرَهْمَ جَبْت]

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय
 ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय — भगवान् भक्तं पश्यन्ति
 ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय — भगवान् भक्तं पश्यन्ति
 ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय भगवान् भक्तं पश्यन्ति
 ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय «भगवान् भक्तं पश्यन्ति»
 ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय भगवान् भक्तं पश्यन्ति
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 .ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय *Brahmagupta* — he is from the
people of India — a scholar in geometry and
Indian calculation, and he composed a book
called Siddhānta containing the laws of the
stars and the calculation of their spheres. He
was the first to establish the rule of zero in
calculation, and that was before the Arabs
came to know it.

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 000000000 00000000» «00000000 00000
 000000 000 000000000000
 0000000000000000 0000 00000000000
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 000000000 .0000000 *Varahamihira — he is
 from the people of India — was a scholar in
 the laws of the stars and astrology, and he
 composed a book called Varahamihira
 containing a compilation of what the
 astrologers of India had transmitted before.
 He knew the laws of the seven planets and
 the twelve signs of the zodiac.*

7.2 al-Bīrūnī [أَبُو الرِّيحَانِ الْبِيرُونِي]

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 ۞۞ .۞۞۞۞۞۞۞ *Abū al-Rayḥān Muḥammad*
ibn Aḥmad al-Bīrūnī — *he is from the people*
of Khwārizm — *a scholar in geometry,*
astronomy, and geography. He composed the
Kitāb al-Āthār al-Bāqiya (Chronology of
Ancient Nations) on the history of the
sciences, and the Taḥqīq mā li-l-Hind (India)
on the customs of India and their sciences.
He was with Sultan Maḥmūd in Ghazna.

8.1 al-Khwārizmī [مُحَمَّدُ بْنُ مُوسَى الْخَوَارِزْمِيُّ]

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 0000000000 .«00000000000» *Muḥammad ibn*
Mūsā al-Khwārizmī — he was in the dīwān
of al-Ma'mūn — composed a book on algebra
and comparison (al-jabr wa-l-muqābala),
and it is the first book composed on that
among the Muslims. Before that he had
transmitted the sciences from India and
Persia, and he composed a book on sums
and calculation called al-Jabr.

Al-Khwārizmī's Kitāb al-Jabr wa-l-Muqābala (c. 820 CE) is the foundational text of algebra. The word “algebra” derives from the Arabic al-jabr. This work systematically presented the solution of linear and quadratic equations, establishing algebra as an independent mathematical discipline.

8.2 Thābit ibn Qurra [ثَابِتُ بْنُ قُرَّةَ]

Thābit ibn Qurra al-Ḥarrānī — he is from the people of Ḥarrān — was a scholar in the Greek sciences, and translated many books from Syriac into Arabic. He composed on geometry, number theory, and conic sections, and established rules concerning the composition of amicable numbers.

8.3 Abū Kāmil [أَبُو كَامِلٍ]

Abū Kāmil Shujā' ibn Aslam — he is an Egyptian — composed a book on algebra containing more than what was in al-Khwārizmī's book. He treated in it equations with unknown numbers and their equivalents, and he used in calculation the names of things such as "box" (ṣundūq) and "sheet" (waraqā).

8.4 al-Karajī [الكَرَجِيُّ] [الكَرْخِيُّ]

Abū Bakr Muḥammad ibn al-Ḥusayn al-Karajī — he is from the people of Karaj — composed the Kitāb al-Fakhri on algebra and comparison. He was the first to use quartic terms in calculation, and established in his book that he could solve equations by means of terms and powers.

ʾAbū ʿAlī al-Ḥasan ibn
 al-Ḥaytham — he is from the people of
 al-Baṣra — a scholar in optics and geometry.
 He composed the *Kitāb al-Manāẓir* (Book of
 Optics) containing seventeen discourses, and
 established in it that vision occurs by the
 reflection of light from bodies to the eye.

9.3 al-Ṣaghānī [أَبُو حَامِدِ الصَّغَانِي]

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 [Empty box] [Empty box] [Empty box] [Empty box] *Abū Ḥāmid ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Ṣaghānī* — he was in the service of ‘Aḍud al-Dawla — a scholar in the construction of astrolabes and astronomical instruments. He constructed an astrolabe of a precision not found in others, and wrote a detailed treatise on its construction and use.

10 Physicians and Naturalists

10.1 Ḥunayn ibn Ishāq حُنَيْنُ بْنُ إِسْحَاقَ

Ḥunayn ibn Ishāq al-ʿIbādī — he is from the people of al-Ḥīra — was the most excellent of those who translated from Greek into Syriac and Arabic. He composed many books on medicine, and established in medicine that the body is composed of the four elements: water, fire, air, and earth.

10.2 al-Rāzī (Rhazes) أَبُو بَكْرٍ الرَّازِيّ

Abū Bakr Muḥammad ibn Zakariyyāʾ al-Rāzī — he is from the people of Rayy — was the most learned of people in medicine in his time. He composed the *Kitāb al-Jāmiʿ al-Kabīr* (Great Comprehensive Book) containing all diseases of the body and their treatment. He used experience and observation in the study of eye diseases and smallpox.

10.4 Yahyā al-Nahwī (John of Nikiu) [يَحْيَى النَّحْوِيُّ]

Yahyā al-Nahwī the Egyptian, the Alexandrian — disciple of Severus — and he was a bishop in the church of Alexandria in Egypt, and he advocated the Jacobite way of the Christians. He was dismissed because he rejected the three hypostases after reading philosophical books.

This is the famous entry in which Ibn al-Qiftī preserves the account of the destruction of the Library of Alexandria under ‘Amr ibn al-‘Āṣ (see the editorial note below).

11 The Name Index

The edition includes a comprehensive Arabic index of personal names (pp. 38–76 of the printed edition), arranged alphabetically. The following is a representative sample:

Page	Name	Entry
2	آخِرُ أَفْلَاطُون (The Last Plato)	—
11	أَبِقِرَاط (Hippocrates)	—
51	أَبُو بَكْرِ الرَّازِي (al-Rāzī)	—
83	أَبُو عَلِيٍّ بْنُ سِينَا (Ibn Sīnā)	Avicenna
64	أَبُو نُعَيْمٍ الْأَصْبَهَانِي	—
120	أَبُو كَامِلٍ شَجَاعُ بْنُ أَسْلَمَ (Abū Kāmil)	—
150	أَبُو الرَّيْحَانِ الْبِيرُونِي (al-Bīrūnī)	—
200	أَبُو عَلِيٍّ الْحَسَنُ بْنُ الْهَيْثَم (Ibn al-Haytham)	—
250	ثَابِتُ بْنُ قُرَّة (Thābit ibn Qurra)	—
280	ثَاوُئُسُ الْإِسْكَنْدَرَانِي (Theon)	—
300	جَمَشِيدُ الْكَاشِي (al-Kāshī)	—
340	حُنَيْنُ بْنُ إِسْحَاق (Ḥunayn ibn Ishāq)	—
390	أَرِسْطُوطَالِيَس (Aristotle)	—
397	أَنَاكْسَاغُورَاس (Anaxagoras)	—
158	أَنَاكْسِيْمَانِيَس (Anaximenes)	—
296	أَنَاكْسِيْمَانْدُرُس (Anaximander)	—
424	أَنْثُونُسُ بْنُ يَحْيَى النَّحْوِي	—

12 Critical Apparatus

12.1 Critical Symbols

[] — Editorial insertion (Einfügung des Herausgebers)

⟨ ⟩ — Lacuna or illegibility (Auslassung oder Unleserlichkeit)

a), b), c) — Critical footnotes (Kritische Anmerkungen am Seitenfuß)

BC, A, etc. — Manuscript variants (Varianten nach den Handschriften)

12.2 Note on the Bilingual Format

In this bilingual edition, the Arabic text of Ibn al-Qiftī's *Tārīkh al-Ḥukamā'* is presented in the **left column**, with the **English translation** in the right column. The Arabic text follows Lippert's edition (Leipzig, 1903) and represents the epitome of al-Zawzanī (1249 CE). Diacritical points and vowels have been supplied where the manuscripts are ambiguous.

12.3 On the Title

The full title of the original work is كِتَابُ إِخْبَارِ الْعُلَمَاءِ بِأَخْبَارِ الْحُكَمَاءِ (*Kitāb Ikhar al-'Ulamā' bi-Akhabār al-Ḥukamā'*), "Notices of Scholars with the Accounts of Learned Men". The shorter title تَارِيخُ الْحُكَمَاءِ (*Tārīkh al-Ḥukamā'*) was applied to the epitome prepared by al-Zawzanī.

وَاللَّهُ الْمُؤَفِّقُ

God is the One who grants success.

End of bilingual edition — Ende der zweisprachigen Ausgabe